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**China's Civilizational Soft Power Strategy:
Wealth, Wisdom, and Global Inclusion**

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Prof. Dr. Chhem Kieth Rethy
Senior Advisor, China-ASEAN Studies Center

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Introduction

China's global rise is no longer measured solely by its economic scale or technological reach, but increasingly by its ability to project soft power through civilizational diplomacy. The Eleventh Nishan Forum on World Civilizations, held in Qufu in July 2025, stands as a quintessential example of this strategy. With participants from over seventy countries across income brackets, religious traditions, and philosophical lineages, the Forum framed China not as a hegemon but as a convener of global wisdom. This essay examines China's soft power through the conceptual lens of civilizational diplomacy, its strategic engagements across wealth-diverse nations, and the scholarly depth of the Forum. It draws on a keynote speech delivered at the Forum to highlight how soft power is increasingly defined by shared ethical traditions, historical connectivity, and epistemological co-creation.

The Concept: Civilizational Diplomacy as Soft Power

At the heart of China's contemporary soft power is the reanimation of ancient civilizational values, particularly Confucian ethics, as a counterweight to Western liberal norms. The theme of the Forum, "Beauty in Diversity: Nurturing Understanding Among Civilizations for Global Modernization," signals an epistemological shift. Rather than seeking uniformity under a single model of progress, China advocates for a multipolar, multicultural modernization. This concept finds intellectual lineage in Confucianism, Daoism, and Buddhist compassion, but also dialogues with Greco-Roman, Islamic, and African philosophical traditions.

China's soft power is thus grounded not in ideological export but in memory, narrative, and reciprocity. It calls not for the abandonment of tradition but its co-evolution with modernity. By invoking civilizational memory, whether from Angkor, Baghdad, Athens, or Chang'an, China seeks to establish legitimacy not only as a developmental leader but as a moral and cultural reference point in global governance.

The Strategy: From Dialogue to Epistemic Infrastructure

The strategic execution of this soft power vision is both symbolic and institutional. The Nishan Forum represents a tiered architecture of influence:

- Epistemic Diplomacy: Through inclusive dialogue with Global South and Western scholars, China reclaims the space of philosophical modernity. It does not challenge the West with confrontation, but with co-authorship of norms.
- People-to-People Bridges: China's evocation of historical figures such as Nāgasena, Mandrasena, and Zhou Daguan demonstrates the *longue durée* of civilizational relationships, especially with countries like Cambodia, India, and Egypt.
- Strategic Partnerships: The Forum encourages investments in academic exchange, joint Confucian and Buddhist studies centers, and shared heritage conservation. In doing so, it institutionalizes its influence across generations of scholars and leaders.

This multilayered strategy blurs the line between soft power and statecraft, binding moral persuasion with tangible partnerships.

Wealth Diversity Among Participating Countries

A striking feature of the Nishan Forum is the economic diversity of its participants, which supports China's goal of creating a global epistemic community across wealth divides. High-income countries such as the US, UK, France, and Japan were represented by prestigious scholars. These nations provide discursive legitimacy to the Forum and lend intellectual parity to China's civilizational vision.

At the same time, upper-middle-income countries like Malaysia, Argentina, Russia, and Turkey, many of them members or observers of the Belt and Road Initiative, reinforce China's geopolitical reach. These states share concerns over Western normative dominance and are receptive to alternative models of modernization.

Perhaps most crucially, lower-middle-income and least-developed countries such as Cambodia, Laos, Egypt, and Madagascar participated not as passive observers but as cultural contributors. Through historical ties, development cooperation, and shared forums, China repositions these states as co-authors of a new world order, thereby deepening south-south solidarity. This aligns with China's promotion of "civilizational equality" over GDP hierarchies.

Intellectual and Scholarly Depth

The intellectual depth of China's soft power was demonstrated through the Forum's rigorous thematic panels, comparative philosophical discourses, and interfaith dialogues. Topics ranged from Confucian ethics in international relations to artificial intelligence and moral governance. The presence of global thought leaders, such as Rethy K. Chhem, Roger T. Ames, Riccardo Pozzo, and Steve Fuller, conveyed a trans-civilizational rigor.

Rethy K. Chhem's keynote speech at the opening ceremony deepened this philosophical engagement by placing Cambodia-China relations within a millennia-old civilizational framework. References to Nagasena and Mandrasena carrying sacred texts to China, and Punyodaya's medical knowledge exchanges, redefined soft power not as policy rhetoric but as living memory. These narratives moved beyond diplomacy into epistemology, linking Buddhist compassion, Confucian duty, and global modernization.

The idea that "modernization must not come at the cost of memory" reframes civilizational exchange as both ethical imperative and strategic necessity. It positions China and Cambodia as co-stewards of ancient wisdom adaptable to digital futures.

Conclusion: A New Paradigm of Global Leadership

Through forums like Nishan, China is not simply asserting itself as a superpower, it is redefining what power means. By cultivating relationships across economic strata, investing in academic and civilizational infrastructure, and promoting ethical co-modernization, it crafts a new model of global leadership.